

Why the Gods CAN'T FAIL

The Hinduism of the future will have to flow with, rather than against, the currents of modernisation and globalisation

— By **WENDY DONIGER**

The genius of Hinduism has always been grounded in its malleability and diversity, its ability to grow and change through its receptivity to the ideas and customs of people other than Hindus. This gives it a terrific edge over those branches of the monotheistic religions (Judaism, Christianity, Islam) that are straitjacketed by a single canon (Bible or Qu'ran) and/or a single governing body (Pope or Ulema). Yet a serious threat to the future of Hinduism is posed by a bad habit that some Hindus have recently caught from the extreme fringes of those monotheisms: fundamentalism. There are many ways to

define fundamentalism, but as US Justice Potter Stewart remarked of pornography, I know it when I see it, and in this context I would define fundamentalism as a fanatical disapproval of people who deviate from a narrowly defined essence of a particular religion.

Fundamentalism is as much a political as a religious phenomenon, and so is Hinduism. Hinduism didn't wake up one morning and discover that it had been metamorphosed into a giant political bug during the night. It was not suddenly politicised by the 19th century nationalists or the 20th century Hindutva demagogues. It was, like most religions, born political, in the sense that it was shaped and constantly changed by its relationship with political actors such as kings with the power to bestow land, Buddhists vying for royal patronage, Muslim rulers who did or did not allow the

building of temples, and above all by the British Raj. Even the caste system, that quintessentially Hindu phenomenon, was configured from the start by the Brahmins' and kings' desire to assimilate and control various foreigners (Scythians, Greeks, Kushanas) and marginal people (such as Adivasis) as well as different political, ethnic and economic factions within the body of Hinduism.

Despite occasional conflicts between competing religions, Hindu interactions with Buddhism and Jainism were generally creative and constructive on both sides, as ideas such as karma, compassion, and non-injury (ahimsa) passed back and forth between the groups, picking up new spins as they moved on. The presence of Muslims in India, too, added momentum to movements such as Bhakti, in part by the positive example set by sects such as Sufis and